prisoner exchanges. Paying such a high price without a proper response would have completely shattered our deterrent capability.

Add to this the fact that on the Israeli side both Prime Minister Ehud Olmert and Defense Minister Amir Peretz were new in their positions and had no previous military or security background. Had they not responded, Hezbollah would have perceived it as weakness and would most certainly have raised the level of its provocations even higher. The international support for the justness of our cause, which is quite rare, also indicated that our response was warranted.

It was a long war (thirty-eight days), longer than any other Israeli war since the War of Independence, with the exception of the War of Attrition, which lasted throughout 1969–70. However, it was an asymmetric war in which a conventional army was fighting against a guerrilla force. As mentioned, the political and military leadership during the Second Lebanon War was inexperienced. The war was completely transparent because of the media's coverage of it in real time. There was a considerable element of psychological warfare in this coverage that inadvertently (and perhaps also intentionally) resulted in damage to national morale. This was the first war in which the moderate Arab world openly supported Israel (including the Lebanese government, albeit secretly). The Second Lebanon War was the first battle in our real campaign against Iran. It was the first major war in which the home front was the main front. (During the First Gulf War, thirty-nine Iraqi missiles fell on the home front, but Israel was totally passive and did not actively engage in the war.) It was a war without a clear victory for the IDF—I will refer to the significance of this in Shiite culture later.

Who were the players in this war?

Iran is a Shiite Muslim state that transformed overnight from a Western secular country into a radical Islamic sharia state in a bloodless coup in 1979. It is a country with huge energy resources, both oil and gas. The export of these energy resources in 2006 brought Iran $60 billion. Until the era of the sanctions imposed on it, Iran experienced growth of 6 percent per year and foreign exchange reserves of $65 billion, which constituted two and a half times the national debt. These data show that in 2006 economic considerations did not constitute a constraint on Iranian decision makers in all their decisions regarding Hezbollah.

Hezbollah is a group of the Shiite ethnicity, which was a minority in Lebanon at the time of the establishment of that country and which today is